ANNUAL MEMBERS:
It's Time to Renew!
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MOUNTAIN REVIEW

OFFICIAL NEWSLETTER OF THE MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION

Volume XIV | Issue 1 | Winter 2024



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Exploring

EL CAMINO REAL

The Story of California's 1st Highway

El Camino Real near Rengstorff Ave at the Mtn. View city limits in the 1960s

Our Winter 2024 Event

Join us as we motor on over to our neighbors in Los Altos and explore the history of El Camino Real, the road that defines our cities' shared border! We'll start our event at the Los Altos Library Community Room where MVHA Board Members will be joined by Jordan Grealish, Exhibits Specialist for the Los Altos History Museum. Through photos and stories, we'll dive into the rich history of California's first highway and Mountain View's original "main street."

After the presentation, we will head next door to the Los Altos History Museum where we will have special after-hours access to the museum's current special exhibition: El Camino Real: Changing California. This exhibit invites you to step back in time through an important part of California's history as you voyage through the rich and sometimes controversial past of El Camino Real, tracing its transformation over the centuries and highlighting local businesses and institutions that once lined the iconic road.



The "birthplace" of Mtn. View; the Taylor Hotel on the site of the town's stagecoach stop on El Camino Real

Sunday, February 4, 2024 ● 3:00 to 5:00 p.m. ● Los Altos Library Community Room, 13 S. San Antonio Road, Los Altos, CA

REGISTER ONLINE: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

News & Notes



MOUNTAIN REVIEW

This newsletter is published four times a year by the
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
P.O. Box 252, Mountain View, CA 94042
www.mountainviewhistorical.org

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Pamela Baird

President's Message

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

Celebrating 70 Years!

This year marks seventy years since the founding of the Mountain View Pioneer and Historical Association. Although the" pioneer" nomenclature is no longer used in the identification of MVHA, it is still the official name of the organization.

When the founding members coalesced to form the group in 1954, there were many descendants of the early families that settled in the area living in Mountain View. The group initially proposed that only members of families that settled in Mountain View prior to 1900 (i.e., "pioneers") would be eligible for membership. Evidently the founders decided that this requirement would be too restrictive and opened the membership to anyone living in Santa Clara County and willing to pay the membership fee.

The group wanted to note the history of people, schools and events in Mountain View. Early efforts included the erection of historic markers around town, including one noting the famed cherry tree located on the former Bubb ranch. The tree was used as a marker for early settlers (See photo above). Another marker, still standing near Rengstorff Avenue and Central Expressway, commemorates the original location of the original homestead of the Castro family, the namesake of Castro Street and owners of the vast Mexican-era Rancho Pastoria de Las Borregas. The last descendent of the Castro family to live in Mountain View, Miss Mercedes Castro, was granted an honorary lifetime membership to our organization when it was founded.

In the 1950s the entire Santa Clara Valley was changing rapidly. In 1950 the census pegged the population of Mountain View at 6,563 people. In the next decade the population exploded to 30,889 residents. Part of the expansion was because the city added surrounding unincorporated areas into the city limits. But a great deal of the growth was due to the subdivisions added to accommodate the returning GI's and their baby boomer children, the growth of technology (Fairchild Industries) and agricultural services (Ferry Morse).

The appearance of Mountain View was much different than today. A road atlas from 1952 shows the Mountain View airport (see the article in this newsletter) located where the soon to be developed Monta Loma neighborhood is now located. Many roads did not connect to other roads, as they ended in orchards and fields. Some major roads, like Middlefield, Ellis and Shoreline, did not exist.

Thanks to the foresight of these "pioneers" the importance of the history of Mountain View was recognized. It is still the goal and mission of MVHA to continue this legacy of documenting and preserving our history.

—Pamela

MV High School Eagles Monument Dedicated!

By Pamela Baird and the MVHS Monument Committee



The Eagle has landed! A bronze sculpture of an eagle is mounted to the top of the new monument at Eagle Park.

The Mountain View High School Eagles soared again on December 16, 2023 when a new monument and historic plaque was dedicated to the accomplishment of the 1975 football team. Against the odds, the small team won the Central Coast Section (CCS) football championship. Attended by team members and supporters, the unveiling ceremony drew over a hundred observers.

Alberto Olmos was the featured speaker. Pamela Baird served as the emcee. Mark Perry gave a spirited retelling of life at Mountain View High School when it was located on Castro Street. Susan Metcalf planned the ceremony (including baking cookies in the shape of footballs).

In 2015 the football team held a forty-year reunion in downtown Mountain View. It was at that reunion the idea of a monument was first discussed. The intention of the monument would be to honor not only the 1975 CCS championship team, but also the entire MVHS Experience.

Several team members approached the MV Historical Association to ask for our help to organize, publicize and raise funds for the monument. Alberto Olmos worked with the Parks and Recreation Department and PRC Commission to gain permission and approval to place a monument in Eagle Park. He researched artists and foundries to locate the eagle sculpture, which stands on a metal framework above the plaque that explains the team, the school and the accomplishment.

Almost fifty years later Mountain View High School alumni, the Mountain View Historical Association with the help of the City of Mountain View have collaborated to place this monument located close to High School Way. Two dedicated benches flank the monument and face what used to be the scoreboard on the north end of the football field.

The next time that you visit Eagle Park be sure to take a look at the monument. It's a great accolade for the team whose motto was "You gotta believe."



MVHA President Pamela Baird welcomes the large crowd gathered in Eagle Park for the dedication of the Mountain View High School monument.



An interpretive sign at the base of the eagle sculpture explains the history of Mountain View High School and how its 1975 football championship brought the city's diverse population together.

Financial Report

By Melissa Rusch
MVHA Treasurer

Checking Account Balance as of 12/31/2023: $18,684.90
10/1/23 - 12/31/23 Income: $1,693.60
10/1/23 - 12/31/23 Expenses: $2,565.98

Key expenditures: Newsletter, "Then & Now" book purchase, Adobe Building Reservation Deposit, website design, accounting software through CPA
Key income: Membership, Donations, book sales, walking tours

Certificates of Deposit: $60,634.23

Membership Report

By Lisa Garcia
MVHA Membership Chair

Happy New Year! I hope everyone is having a productive beginning of the year. It's membership renewal time. Thank you to those of you who have already renewed!! You can mail in your form (see page 9) with a check or go online at: www.mountainviewhistorical.org/memberships/

We would like to welcome our new members:

- Elizabeth Wagstaff & Joe Medwid
- Joe & Liz Gonzales
- Nijanth Anand
-

Thank you James Kinchen for becoming a lifetime member!

I look forward to seeing you all at our next event.

An Airfield Across the Street?

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

Several years ago while looking at a map book of Santa Clara County from 1954 I was totally flabbergasted to see that there used to be an airfield across the street from where my husband and I live. I had never heard anything about this before! And thus began my search to learn more about the history of this little-known place.

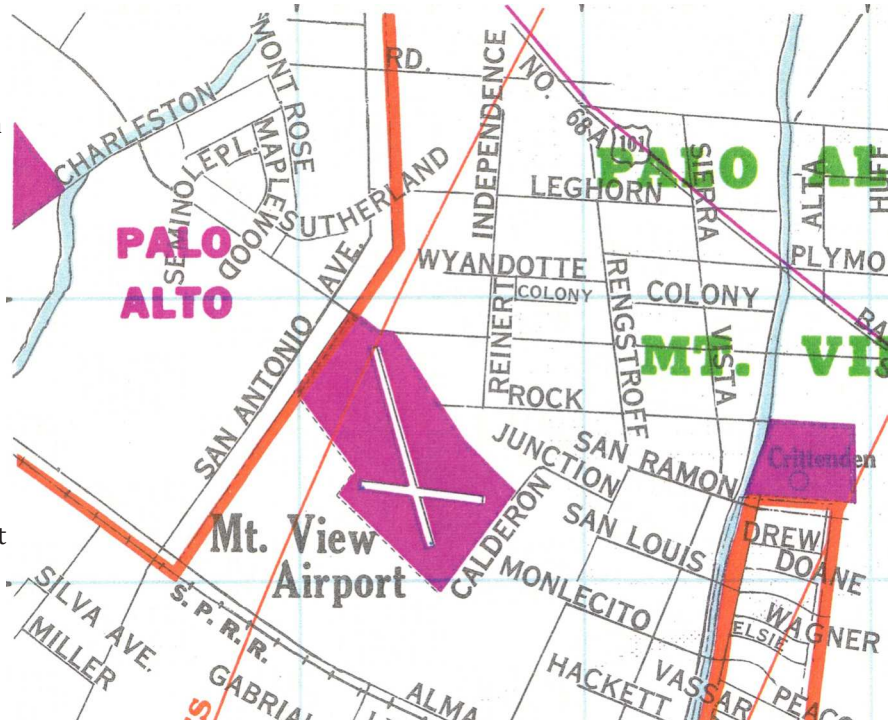
Established in 1936 as the "Progressive Air Service, Mountain View Airport" by John Simonic as an airfield for private, commercial and flight training courses, it featured two intersecting air strips. General aircraft maintenance and repairs were conducted in the several buildings on the property. The airstrips were dirt. The field covered about 50 acres. The surrounding area was open fields. The flight school was also used by students of the Aviation Department of San Jose State University, who were working towards achieving a commercial or private pilot's license. The 1941 SJSU yearbook contains information about the program.

The instructors were approved by the Civil Aviation Administration. According to the M*ountain View Register Leader* newspaper, Manuel Nunes of Mountain View was the first graduate of the air school in 1936. He was thirty years old with a wife and two children. A search for more information yielded nothing, but it is probable that he was a member of the extended Nunes family that originally immigrated from the Azores.

A much younger student from rural Santa Clara, Albert Santos, aged 21, received his first flight instruction in 1939. He first soloed in a 35 horsepower (a small sized engine) biplane. He gained further flying skills in a larger Fleet biplane (a plane often used for training). Albert joined the Army Air Corps in February 1942 and received extensive training at air bases in Florida and South Carolina over the next year. He was stationed north of London in 1944. During this assignment he would log 320 flying hours on 66 combat missions in the P-51 B bomber. After thirty-six years of military service, he retired in 1978 as a brigadier general.

A tragic event is associated with the airport. In January of 1947, a small plane crashed near Rengstorff and Alma Street, killing the pilot Elmer Hartzler and severely injuring the passenger, Percy Jarvis. The two men were flying a Fairchild PT-19, which was designed as a tandem two-seat primary trainer for use by the Army Air Corps. Evidently the plane was attempting to land at the airfield and stalled at an altitude of about 100 feet, according to a report in the January 6, 1947, *Mountain View Register-Leader*. The two had taken off from the airport in San Carlos on a short pleasure trip.

Encroaching interests threatened the airport during the late 1940s. In February of 1945, John Simonic was concerned about the possible addition of electric and telephone lines nearby that could interfere with landing approaches. He asked the city for help in locating the lines out of the approach areas.



Map showing the location of the Mountain View Airport in the present-day Monta Loma neighborhood.

In June of 1949, the Santa Clara County planning commission denied a permit request from a company to build and operate a skeet and trap shooting range near Alma and San Antonio Road. John Simonic protested against the permit because he was concerned about the danger of planes being hit by misplaced shots.

A long time former resident of Monta Loma, Ben Baumgartner, is quoted in 2010 on the Monta Loma Neighborhood Association website regarding his experiences. "I am probably the only person living in the area, or alive today, who has flown out of that airport. During the war (1941–45) the airport was closed, but around 1944, when I was 13, some friends and I rode our bikes out there. We went into the hangers and sat in some of the planes and played with the controls."

"Sometime after the war, possibly in 1947, my brother had a friend who worked at the airport and had learned to fly. He bought a surplus Stearman biplane trainer [Editor's note-formerly used as a military trainer aircraft during World War II-over 10,000 were built] and took me up in it. I still remember that flight. I stuck my head out into the 90-mile-per-hour airstream to look at the ground falling away and the cars on Middlefield Road. The runway went almost to Middlefield. Some planes were still low as they flew over the road and startled the drivers passing under them. The block of Alvin north of Victory was one-half of the runway, with the end at Elka Street."

But change was inevitable due to the rapid growth of the surrounding areas. Forty acres of land were sold for housing developments in 1952. Companies owned by Joseph Eichler and John Mackay and the Mardell Building Company built hundreds of homes by the late 1950s. The area is now known as the Monta Loma neighborhood.

It's amazing to think that the Monta Loma neighborhood is the former location of such a progressive and short-lived business enterprise.

Finding Your Family History

By Robert Cox
MVHA Vice President

Any person seeking to preserve a detailed record of his or her family history should seriously consider purchasing high-quality personal genealogy software. It is the only way to be certain that your hard work will never be lost.

Genealogy companies like Ancestry or MyHeritage offer you the opportunity to start to build your family tree for free, but you will eventually end up paying a subscription fee. These fees are generally several hundred dollars per year. If at some point you decide you are finished with your work, or do not want to pay the ongoing fee, you will still want to have a copy of your work. Both Ancestry and MyHeritage allow you to create a GEDCOM file, which contains the basic information in your family tree. But it may not be complete with all the references in their databases or preserve accessible links to photos, especially those in other people's accounts.

Free online genealogy projects like Wikitree pose other problems for those seeking to keep a permanent record of their work. Wikitree has become increasing restrictive in the management of profiles of living people. Furthermore, the Wikitree management frequently creates new rules for its profiles. The management then requires contributors to go back and redo their profiles according to these new rules. This work of redoing profiles can take away valuable time from your family history research. Wikitree reserves the right to delete any profiles for any reason. Several people I know have lost years of work after their contributions were deleted due to non-conformance with Wikitree's changing policies.

There are quite a few personal genealogy software packages from which to choose. What is best for you will depend on several factors: the cost of the package, whether a free trial version is offered, its ability to work with online services like Ancestry and MyHeritage, how well it can import and merge GEDCOMs created from other platforms, whether it is supported on Windows and/or Mac, the personal appeal of its user interface, and the types of charts and reports which can be generated automatically from the data that you enter.

In my personal search for the best personal genealogy software, I did a detailed evaluation of three major packages: Family Tree Maker, Family Historian, and Roots Magic. In my next column, I will share my experience and recommendations.



Downtown Tokyo in 1969; The year former mayor Margaret Abe-Koga's parents immigrated to California.

Mtn. View Family History Fun Fact!

In Japanese culture, the phrase "Kodomo no tame ni" which means "Sacrifice for the sake of the children, for the future," is a key value. This phrase sums up the life of the parents of council member and former Mountain View mayor Margaret Abe-Koga. Margaret's parents immigrated to the United States from Japan in 1969. They grew up during World War II-torn Japan and had their education cut short. Margaret's father was orphaned at age 15. His father was a merchant marine who went out to sea during the War one day and never returned. Margaret's paternal grandmother died two years later.

Margaret's mother was the daughter of a confectioner and farmer and was the only daughter out of six children. She was often sent to help other families with childcare even as a child herself. Margaret's mom moved to the big city of Tokyo at age 18 and worked a variety of jobs as did her dad. They met working at a bakery in Tokyo and married.



Margaret Abe-Koga's parents and her daughters



The Abe's, Margaret Abe-Koga's paternal grandparents.

Margaret's great aunt had immigrated to the U.S. earlier in the sixties and urged her father to come visit and consider immigrating as well. Pregnant with Margaret, her mom and dad came to the United States and while visiting, Margaret's mother gave birth to her at Stanford Hospital.



The Saito's, Margaret Abe-Koga's maternal grandparents.



ABOVE: Margaret (at right) and her family at the Fushimi Inari (伏見稲荷大社) Shrine on a recent trip to Japan.

Margaret's parents had to decide whether to return to Japan or immigrate to the U.S. They told her that they immigrated because they felt as a female she would have more opportunities in the U.S. – "for the sake of their child". They settled in San Mateo. They never felt comfortable speaking English language. Her dad was a gardener. Her mom started out as a housecleaner and later worked for Japan Airlines making the flight meals. They lived a modest life, and Margaret served as their translator as soon as she learned English. Margaret recalls, "I saw through their eyes the struggle and hardship as immigrants without a voice in the community. This experience is what has compelled me to work towards ensuring that everyone regardless of background has a voice in our community."



THE EVOLUTION OF:

EL CAMINO REAL

Looking Back at the Local History of California's First Highway

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

El Camino Real. The Royal Road. The San Francsico-San Jose Road. Highway 101. Highway 82. ECR. No matter what's it's been called, El Camino Real is a story of colonization, conversion, coercion, connections, and commerce.

Before the arrival of the Spanish, indigenous people lived throughout California. Whether living in coastal, desert or mountainous regions, the many tribes had survived and prospered for thousands of years. They created many paths and trails used for trade, communication and hunting. Those trails were later used by the Spanish as they moved into Alta (Upper) California to establish missions, presidios (forts) and pueblos (towns). As more missions were founded, the trail and roadway used to connect these outposts was called "El Camino Real" because it was financed by the Spanish crown.

Led by priests of the Catholic church, the missions were created by a religious zeal to convert the indigenous peoples to Catholicism and establish a "better" way of life through farming and industry. Twenty one missions were built in areas containing access to water, good soil and nearby indigenous people. It's a common misconception that the missions were spaced a day's walk apart. Some were, like the missions now located in San Jose and Fremont. These two centers were about 14 miles apart. The average distance between the missions is about 30 miles, a two day walk or a long day on horseback.

Mexico gained independence from Spain in 1821. Life changed little, other than the people in Alta California now called themselves "Californios." In 1834, Mexico secularized all church property and many missions were no longer supported by the Catholic church. Most fell into disrepair. After the Mexican American war (1846-1848) the Mexican Republic was forced to relinquish any claim to California to the United States.

The California Gold Rush (1849-1855) brought many people to northern California, which increased the need for better roads and settlements, many starting along one of the few established transit routes—El Camino Real.



ABOVE: Picket fences line both sides of an unpaved El Camino Real in this early 1900s photo. The building in the background is the Mtn. View Elementary School, built in 1872, now the location of the Two Worlds development.

San Francisco became the starting point for many gold seekers. San Jose became the state Capital (California became the 31st state in 1850) so a better road was needed between the two cities. Most of El Camino Real was incorporated into a stagecoach route. The road became known as the "San Francisco-San Jose Road".

The increasing transit along the road created the need for services, such as lodging, liveries and stores. Small settlements along the road increased the local population. In 1852 the town of Mountain View (so named in 1854) was founded as a stagecoach stop on El Camino Real near the crossing of Stevens Creek. It quickly grew to have homes, several hotels and saloons, two general merchandise stores, a livery, lumber yard and grammar school.

Continued on next page

El Camino Real (Cont. from Page 6)









ABOVE: Postcard for one of many motels built along El Camino Real when it served as the route of U.S. 101. RIGHT: A selection of matchbook covers from various businesses along El Camino Real in Mtn. View.

Even when the new railway arrived in 1864 and ended the stagecoach business, commerce and transit was needed on a road that traversed the length of the peninsula. El Camino Real served local communities for short distances by buggy or horse drawn wagons between towns along the route.

For decades the road remained a rough, pitted dirt passageway. The new technological advance of the automobile could barely traverse the road, with ten miles per hour being the safe speed. A newly established State Bureau of Highways designated El Camino Real the first state highway in 1911. The two lane highway would be paved from San Francisco to Gilroy in the 1910s.

As the area grew in population from the expanding agricultural output of Santa Clara County, El Camino Real adapted with an increase in commercial, restaurants and business options. The auto-oriented character of El Camino Real developed in the 1920s. Not only was local commerce developed, the growing industry of car travel meant that motor lodges, tire retailers, gas stations and car repair companies were needed to service the increased acceptance of the automobile.

It was in the mid-1920s that El Camino Real was named Highway 101, which increased its predominance as the route for travelers. In the 1940s and 1950s a large number of apricot and prune (plum) orchards still existed on or near El Camino Real in Los Altos, Mountain View and Sunnyvale.

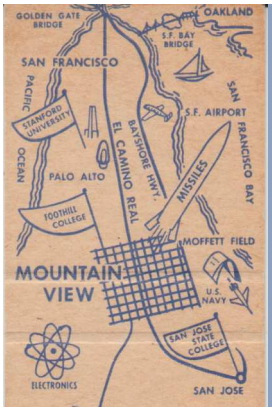


ABOVE: The 1940 grand opening of the Art Deco style Mancini Motors on El Camino Real. For more information on this unique El Camino Real landmark, see page 10!

But as the area grew in population and industry expanded (electronics, aerospace, publishing, the nearby Naval Air Station, and the emerging computer industry) El Camino became a long commercial district. Gas stations, grocery stores, auto oriented businesses, restaurants and even a drive-in movie theater and bowling alley filled the former agricultural land. Local favorite drive-in restaurants catered to the many families living in the area.

Several road widening projects were built to accommodate the increased traffic and create a safer and more beautiful travel route. Some of the efforts were controversial, as change can be disruptive, but were deemed necessary. These were accomplished in the 1930s, 1960s and the 1980s.

By the late 1960s El Camino Real in Mountain View was mostly lined with auto-oriented businesses and remained this way until the early 2000s when mixed use housing construction began replacing businesses. Today, Mountain View's stretch of El Camino Real is an ever-changing mix of commercial, retail and housing.



Learn more about the history of El Camino Real at the next MVHA general event on February 4! See Page 1 for more information. To RSVP, please register at: *mvhistory.eventbrite.com*

History Happening Now

Google Visitor Experience Opens to Public



ABOVE: The new Gradient Canopy building at 2000 N Shoreline Blvd. in Mountain View's North Bayshore is now home to the Google Visitor Experience.

By Pamela Baird
MVHA President

In the North Bayshore area of Mountain View a wonderful destination has been opened at the new Google Gradient Canopy office building. After several years of construction, the building opened in the fall of 2023. A portion of the building contains space for a café, a community meeting room, a pop up store featuring local artists, an area displaying Google products and large sculptures in an outdoor plaza.

Snaking around the building and through the 18-acre site is a dedicated Green Loop with bicycle and pedestrian paths. Sustainable landscaping around the site incorporates demonstration planting beds and pollinator elements for monarch butterflies. Three bee boxes are located on the property.

The café features reasonably priced sandwiches, soups, salads and desserts using locally sourced ingredients. Seating is available inside or outside on the patio.

The Huddle is an area that can be used by community groups at no charge for lectures, meetings and events. The outdoor art installation contains ten large pieces of imaginative sculptures that invite close inspection.

The Visitor Experience is open daily.

For more information visit:

https://visit.withgoogle.com/







New outdoor art installations have been placed all around the North Bayshore. A few of them are shared here, from left to right: "Curious" a bear made of pennies, "The Orb", and "Halo."

Mtn View's Mayor & Vice Mayor for 2024

By Nicholas Perry
MVHA Past President

On January 9, the Mountain View City Council voted unanimously to appoint Pat Showalter as mayor of Mountain View and Lisa Matichak as vice mayor for 2024. Mayor Showalter previously served as mayor in 2016 during her first term on the City Council. Vice Mayor Matichak previously served as mayor in 2019 and vice mayor in 2018. Congratulations to Mayor Showalter and Vice Mayor Matichak!



Mayor Pat Showalter



Vice Mayor Lisa Matichak

Fall Event Recap



By Nick Perry
MVHA Past President

In honor of Shoreline at Mountain View's 40th anniversary, the MVHA welcomed Brady Ruebusch, Shoreline Manager for the City of Mountain View as our special guest speaker at our fall event. Attendees enjoyed an informative slideshow presentation on the past, present and future of the Shoreline Regional Park Community. Thanks to Brady and to all who joined us for the event!



The City of Mountain View's poster commemorating the 40th anniversary of Shoreline at Mountain View.



Guest speaker Brady Ruebusch and MVHA past president Nick Perry smile for photo after Brady's talk. The event served as a reunion for the two; In the early 2000s Brady and Nick were founding members of the City of Mountain View's Youth Advisory Group (now the Youth Advisory Committee).

✂

HAPPY NEW YEAR! Annual Members, it's Time to Renew for 2024! Please Mail Form Below or Renew Online

MEMBERSHIP FORM

The MVHA welcomes new members! You can also join/renew online at **www.mountainviewhistorical.org**. Membership is tax deductible to the extent permitted by law. The MVHA is a tax-exempt organization under Internal Revenue Code Section 501(c)(3), Tax ID 94-6115407.

- ☐ New Membership
- ☐ Membership Renewal
- ☐ Household Annual Membership *$30/year*
- ☐ Individual Lifetime Membership *$300*
- ☐ *I'm interested in volunteer opportunities*

Name(s): _____

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Thank you!

WINTER/SPRING

February 4
Sunday, 2:00 to 4:00 p.m.
MVHA Spring Event & Meeting
Los Altos Library & History Museum
See page 1 for more info!

February 5 & March 4
Wednesday, 6:00 p.m. to 8:00 p.m.
MVHA Board Meeting
Virtual Zoom meeting
All interested members welcome to attend! Email info@mountainviewhistorical.org for log-in

Jan. 28, Feb. 25 & March 24
Sunday, 2:00 p.m. to 3:00 p.m.
Downtown Walking Tours
Centennial Plaza, 600 W. Evelyn Ave, Mtn. View
Details at: http://mvhistory.eventbrite.com

Save the Date!
May 5
Sunday, 2:00 p.m. to 4:00 p.m.
MVHA Spring Meeting
Adobe Building, 157 Moffett Blvd., Mtn. View
More details in our Spring Newsletter!

Looking Back: Images from the Archives



In this image from our archives, a man stands "on top of the world" as the iconic Mancini Motors tower is installed on El Camino Real near Castro Street, c. 1940. Also note the house visible to the left of the tower; it still stands today at 680 Yosemite Avenue.

Italian Immigrant Ugo Mancini came to Mountain View in 1911 and operated a variety of automobile-related businesses along El Camino Real, culminating with the opening of the landmark Mancini Motors complex in 1940. Ugo purchased the Chrylser Exhibit from the Golden Gate International Exhibition on Treasure Island in San Francisco for $3,000. He incorporated elements of the exhibit into his new dealership, including the 20-ton, 52-foot high stainless steel tower topped by a 9-foot revolving globe. The tower remained an El Camino Real landmark until the Mancini family sold the property in 1974 and the present-day bank building was constructed at the location. The site is now slated for redevelopment again.

EST. 1954
MOUNTAIN REVIEW
MOUNTAIN VIEW HISTORICAL ASSOCIATION
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